



On the shore

Many sea creatures live on tidal shores because they can find a lot to eat there. But seashores are dangerous places. They are exposed to waves that toss rocks around, crushing any animals that are in the way. Tidal zones also dry out at low tide—something that would kill most marine life. Few species are equipped to survive, but these few often flourish in vast numbers.

STRONG SHELLS

On rocky shores, many animals such as these limpets and barnacles have strong shells to resist the crash of the waves. The barnacles open up to gather food when they are submerged at high tide, while the larger limpets creep around, grazing on algae. But they all clamp shut or squeeze down tight when the falling tide leaves them exposed.



SLIPPERY SEAWEED

Like the attached animals of rocky shores, many coastal seaweeds can survive drying out as the tide falls twice a day. They grow in distinct zones, with a few very tough species growing high on the shore, and a much greater variety growing low down in the zone that is usually underwater.

◀ SHOREWEED

Rocks on the lower shore are often thick with layers of seaweed that flourish in the shallow, sunlit water.

CLAMS AND WORMS

Sandy shores are colonized by millions of burrowing animals. They include various types of clams, such as cockles, and marine worms like the lugworms that pushed up these worm casts. Most either feed on edible debris in the sand, or draw plankton-rich water into their bodies when they are submerged at high tide.

